



Research paper

Early childhood teacher identity development for working with culturally and linguistically diverse students in Chile

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ARTICLE INFO

Article history:

Received 11 April 2022

Received in revised form

7 April 2023

Accepted 18 May 2023

Available online 24 May 2023

Keywords:

Teacher identity

Teacher education

Cultural diversity

Linguistic diversity

ABSTRACT

This study investigates how three recently graduated early childhood educators in Chile construct teacher identities related to working with culturally and linguistically diverse (CLD) students. This multiple case study analyzes written narratives and interviews. Findings show that participants construct teacher identities that position them as advocates for CLD students, grounded on their personal identities and previous experiences, and expanded during the teacher education program. In this article, I argue that whereas participants constructed an identity for working with CLD students despite having graduated from a program that did not include those contents, the development of pedagogical skills is still needed.

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“Actualmente, tenemos muchos estudiantes de familias muy diversas y, al parecer, no estábamos preparados para poder recibir esta diversidad como una oportunidad” [Currently, we have many students of very diverse families and, apparently, we were not prepared to welcome this diversity as an opportunity] (Toti, interview).

Toti, a recently graduated early childhood teacher in Chile, reflects on what she has seen in classrooms as a student teacher. Her words are a manifestation of a Chilean reality: while classrooms are becoming more culturally and linguistically diverse, teachers are not ready to embrace diverse populations in their classrooms, and teacher education has not been up to date to support this need. In this article, I worked with recently graduated early childhood teachers from Santiago, Chile, to investigate how they have constructed professional identities to work with culturally and linguistically diverse (CLD) students. I argue that, despite having graduated from a program that did not include elements of cultural and linguistic diversity, participants were able to construct a teacher identity to work with CLD students. While this is a valuable starting point that teacher education programs should use in their favor, there is still a need to develop specific pedagogical skills that allow new teachers to support their CLD students better.

From 1990 to the late 2010s, Chile experienced an increase in the

foreign-born population from 0.8% to 5% of the total population (Department of Economic and Social Affairs of the United Nations, 2019). Recent research indicates that 14% of youth come from immigrant origin (United Nations, Department of Economic and Social Affairs, Population Division, 2019). However, educational policies to support immigrant students in this country have not advanced sufficiently to offer them the education they deserve. Educational politics regarding diversity have focused on educating students from indigenous backgrounds (MINEDUC, Chile, 2020).¹ Immigrant students' access to the educational system was only addressed in 2018, with “Política Nacional de Estudiantes Extranjeros” (PNEE; National Policy for Foreign Students). This policy focuses on improving access to public education and education resources but does not include a new frame to integrate immigrant students' cultures or languages within curricular offerings (MINEDUC, Chile, 2018).

Despite these recent policy attempts to address the shifts in the student population, teacher education programs in Chile have slowly incorporated the topic of cultural diversity into their curriculum. In many cases, cultural diversity is added in the form of a single survey course broadly focused on issues of diversity, which may also include special educational needs, the education of

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¹ The policy of “Educación Intercultural” (Intercultural Education) is aimed at schools with 20% or more indigenous students and institutions that intend to favor interculturality (MINEDUC, Chile, 2020).

students belonging to indigenous groups, gender and sexual diversity (Carmona Toro & Naudon Gaete, 2018). In most cases, diversity is conceived as an overarching concept (Cabezas et al., 2019; Infante y; Matus, 2009; San Martín et al., 2017). By conflating all matters of diversity into the same category, those courses are not able to give student teachers the knowledge and skills they need to apply to be successful teachers of CLD students.

Furthermore, the addition of cultural diversity to teacher education programs is not reflected in documents written by educational agencies, with influence over curricular reforms at a national level. In the case of programs that prepare early childhood teachers, they have an average duration of eight to nine semesters, during which students take pedagogical and content area coursework, and participate in multiple instances of practicum work, ranging from purely observational to overseeing whole sessions. While teacher education programs do not follow a set curriculum, they are guided by the standards for teacher preparation programs in early childhood education (Estándares Orientadores para Carreras de Educación Parvularia, MINEDUC, Chile, 2012). The inclusion of cultural diversity in those standards is only by mentioning cultural knowledge in the description of two of them, in which culture is associated with families and children's background but not in clear connection with the development of teachers' cultural competences and pedagogical skills. Meanwhile, linguistic diversity has not been included in any standard for the preparation of early childhood teachers.

In connection with this evidence, research has described that student teachers and in-service teachers evaluate their preparation to work in contexts of cultural diversity as a weak aspect of their teacher education. They describe having a lack of competences in planning, evaluating, and adapting their teaching to culturally diverse students (Gaete et al., 2016; Sanhueza Henríquez et al., 2016; Ruffinelli, 2013). The limited skills and knowledge to work with CLD students that new teachers develop in their teacher preparation programs puts in risk the educational experience of diverse students in Chilean classrooms.

Considering the growing diversity in the student population, and the scarcity and superficiality of cultural and linguistic diversity in the preparation and standards for early childhood educators in Chile, it is relevant to understand how recently graduated teachers conceptualize their professional identities for working with culturally and linguistically diverse students before entering the teaching profession. This paper contributes to the literature on teacher preparation to work with culturally and linguistically diverse students in Chile by giving insights into professional identity construction of recently graduated early childhood teachers, related to the features of their teacher education program that prepared them to work with CLD students, and what personal and professional experiences have supported the development of their teaching identity to work in contexts of diversity. Learning from newly graduated teachers' accounts of their teacher education programs can help policymakers and institutional actors better understand the current assets, preparation challenges, and areas of further development within the existing curricula.

In this study, I worked with three newly graduated early childhood teachers from Santiago, Chile, treating each participant as a case. I asked each participant to write a personal narrative about the factors that have influenced their teacher identity to work with CLD students. Later, I interviewed each participant to delve deeper into the same topics. I analyzed both data sources to investigate the following research questions: How do three recently graduated early childhood educators in Santiago, Chile, articulate the development of their teacher identities related to working with culturally and linguistically diverse (CLD) students? Which factors do they describe as influencing their teacher identity development?

1. Teaching culturally and linguistically diverse students

For prospective teachers to work successfully with culturally and linguistically diverse students, they must have developed the attitudes, knowledge, and skills necessary to support those students in their learning process (Villegas & Lucas, 2002). Several scholars have contributed to advancing theoretical principles and practical orientations to define how teacher education programs should prepare educators to develop those features.

Gloria Ladson Billings' (1995, 2021) theory of culturally relevant pedagogy proposed that "culturally relevant teaching must meet three criteria: an ability to develop students academically, a willingness to nurture and support cultural competence, and the development of a sociopolitical or critical consciousness" (Ladson-Billings, 1995, p. 483). Geneva Gay (2002) coined the term culturally responsive teaching to describe what teachers should be doing in the classroom. For her, culturally responsive teaching means: "developing a knowledge base about cultural diversity, including ethnic and cultural diversity content in the curriculum, demonstrating caring and building learning communities, communicating with ethnically diverse students, and responding to ethnic diversity in the delivery of instruction" (Gay, 2002, p. 106).

Villegas and Lucas (2002) extended this work through their interest in the preparation of teachers. They offered an organizing framework for preparing culturally responsive teachers, and later a related one for preparing linguistically responsive teachers. This last framework consist of three orientations —inclinations toward ideas or actions, influenced by attitudes and beliefs— and four language-related knowledge and skills (Lucas & Villegas, 2010). According to these authors, linguistically responsive teaching education should include the development of (1) Sociolinguistic consciousness; (2) Value for linguistic diversity; (3) An inclination to advocate for English Language Learners (ELLs) students; (4) Learning about ELL students' language backgrounds, experiences, and proficiencies; (5) Identifying the language demands of classroom discourse and tasks; (6) Knowing and applying key principles of second language learning; and (7) Scaffolding instruction to promote ELL students' learning (Lucas & Villegas, 2010).

Another construct to conceptualize the skillset that teachers need to develop to work in contexts of cultural diversity is intercultural competence. This concept refers to having adequate knowledge (of the self, of language and communication, and the world), values (such as diversity, inclusion, human rights, and justice), attitudes (of openness, respect, and responsibility, to name a few), skills (such as co-operation, conflict-resolution, and communicative) and put them into action in interaction with others from different cultures (Pastori et al., 2018; UnescoLeeds-Hurwitz & Stenou, 2013). Research has found that PD that aims to develop intercultural competences in teachers does not necessarily led to a change in teaching practices (Romjin et al., 2021). Translating new knowledge, values, and skills is hard for new and experienced teachers for the difficulty of changing long held beliefs (Civitillo et al., 2018), and also because of structural features of their work settings (Daniel & Pray, 2017; Leeman & Van Koeven, 2019). The development of intercultural competence in the context of teacher education programs, then, cannot be successfully implemented if isolated from practicum experiences or as a brief theoretical review.

The model of intercultural competence is helpful for this study because it has been used extensively in professional development initiatives for professionals who work with children in diverse contexts (Pastori et al., 2018; Romjin et al., 2021). Nevertheless, the knowledge, values, attitudes, and skills included in the model of intercultural competences do not cover aspects of linguistic diversity needed to support the needs of CLD students in increasingly diverse school contexts, such as the Chilean.

These conceptualizations of what it means to be a culturally and linguistically relevant, responsive, or culturally competent teacher offer a valuable theoretical frame for this study. From different perspectives and with different goals, those models offer different lenses to identifying which features, according to each theoretical model, the participants of this study have already acquired and which are not yet developed. Using those different frameworks will be useful to understand the teacher identity development to work with CLD students of recently graduated early childhood teachers in Chile.

2. Teacher identity

In contrast with modern conceptions of identity, from a post-modern perspective, identity is not conceptualized as stable, continuous, or individual (Akkerman, Meijer, Aronson, & Laughter, 2016). Teacher identity, then, is conceived as a process of the self, continually being constructed and reconstructed in time as individuals develop in their interaction with others (Cooper & Olson, 1996, pp. 78–89). While the postmodern take on identity has allowed researchers to describe how individuals' identity positions change through time and according to different situations and persons, it does not explain how individuals are able to maintain a sense of self and individuality (Akkerman et al., 2016).

A dialogical approach to identity takes both perspectives and considers identity as simultaneously unitary and multiple, continuous and discontinuous, and individual and social (Akkerman et al., 2016). Influenced by Bakhtin's ideas, the theory of the Dialogical Self proposes the existence of multiple I-positions stemming from different social and cultural origins, which may hold a diversity of stances (Hermans, 2001; Hermans et al., 1992). Those I-positions interact with each other and are held together in the unity of self that is constituted through self-dialogue (Akkerman et al., 2016). From this dialogical approach, Akkerman et al. (2016) define teacher identity "as an ongoing process of negotiating and inter-relating multiple I-positions in such a way that a more or less coherent and consistent sense of self is maintained throughout various participations and self-investments in one's (working) life" (p. 315). This dialogical conception of teacher identity will allow an understanding of the processual aspects of identity development of recently graduated teachers, while describing the elements that delineate their individual selves.

The literature on teacher identity, from diverse theoretical perspectives, has been interested in investigating the components of the teacher self (Bukor, 2015; Cooper & Olson, 1996; Flores & Day, 2006; MacLure, 1993). Olsen (2008), operating under a sociocultural model of identity, considers teacher identity as a dynamic, holistic integration among multiple parts that include reasons for entry into the profession, teacher education experience, current teaching context/practice, career plans, prior personal experiences, and prior professional experiences (including working with kids). Those elements of the teacher self can be understood as the source of some of the I-positions that interact to constitute a teacher's identity from a dialogical perspective. The identification of those components can be helpful to connect the diverse I-positions with their cultural and social origins.

This study will add to this body of literature and contribute to our understanding of how recently graduated early childhood teachers in Chile are developing their teacher identity for working with culturally and linguistically diverse students. It will explore the factors influencing teacher identity and how their current identity is positioned for working with CLD students in the Chilean educational context.

3. Methods

3.1. Researcher positionality

I am a Chilean woman who, for this project, conducted research in my own country, and in my home language, Spanish. I have several years of experience working in teacher education in the Chilean context, specifically in early language acquisition and early literacy. My cultural and professional position was an asset for this study, in which the participants were recently graduated early childhood teachers from Chile. Still, I am also aware of the complexities of my relationship with the participants. As their former instructor in courses of early language development and early literacy, I understand that this previous academic relationship influences the views and experiences participants shared with me. In that sense, my role as a researcher lives in a space between being an insider and an outsider of the participants' perspectives, a place where I can access a deeper knowledge of their experiences but not a complete understanding of them (Dwyer & Buckle, 2009).

3.2. Research design

To answer the research questions, I employed a multiple case study design in which each of the recently graduated early childhood teachers is considered a case. In this study, I identified themes in the development and expression of teacher identities while conceptualizing each participant as a unique case that should not be generalized to a population (Stake, 2013).

3.3. Participants

Three participants were purposefully selected to develop information-rich cases (Patton, 2002). I used a homogenous sample strategy (Patton, 2002) because I intended to describe the experiences of a particular group of professionals while acknowledging the likely personal differences that would exist within the group. This professional group is a cohort of recently graduated early childhood educators in Santiago, Chile, who attended the same 4-year program at a private university. At the time of data collection, from March to April 2021, they had not started working in classrooms. I was already familiar with them, as I was their instructor in two required courses in early language development and early literacy within their program between 2018 and 2019.

I recruited participants from that cohort of early childhood teachers, which resulted in the selection of three participants: Estela, Toti, and Emilia (pseudonyms). Participants who agreed to be part of the study were among those students with whom I had maintained a mentorship relationship after they were students in my courses. Therefore, in this multiple case study, a purposeful sample was built on existing relationships, allowing for rich data collection and investigation of the research questions.

Estela was 23 years old at the time of data collection. She is an outspoken woman who is passionate about teaching. After finishing high school, she enrolled in a BA in Fine Arts for two years. After that, Estela worked as a paraprofessional in a preschool for one and a half years, where she discovered her disposition to work with young children. She continually reflects on issues related to language and literacy. Estela connects her theoretical reflections to her teaching and personal experiences as a friend of immigrant people in Chile.

Toti was 23 years old when participating in the study. Being a member of the LGBTQI+ community is a key element in her teacher identity. As a teenager, she went to a vocational school,

where she graduated as a paraprofessional. After that, Toti decided to become an early childhood teacher, despite family pressures to get a more profitable degree. Toti is particularly interested in school integration of students with disabilities. While she was a student teacher, she served as a TA for the course Special Educational Needs in Early Childhood. Toti also worked as a tutor for students with disabilities in her university, as part of a Program of Inclusion.

Emilia was 23 years old as a participant in the study. She has a strong commitment to justice and sees education as a way to achieve a more just world. Since high school, her empathy led her to volunteer at different institutions. In one of those instances, when working in a rural school in the south of Chile, she realized she wanted to be a teacher. While in college, she volunteered at a foundation that works with physically disabled children, and also worked in an initiative on adult literacy at a public university in Chile.

Table 1 provides additional information about the participants in this study.

3.4. Data collection

For this study, I collected data from two sources: written personal narratives and semi-structured interviews. These sources of data are used to allow the participants to clarify, deepen, and construct meaning differently in each instance (alone and with the interviewer). Data for this project was collected in Spanish, the native language of the researcher and the participants.

Written narratives. The written narratives were designed to allow the participants to reflect on their own experiences and give them meaning (Freda & Martino, 2015; Lieblich, 2012; cited in Esposito & Freda, 2016). The written format allows participants to work reflexively and think more extensively about their ideas. In this case, recently graduated early childhood teachers had the chance to think individually about their identities and to take their time to register those reflections in a written format. Each participant wrote one personal narrative of 500–800 words about how 1) their biographies, 2) the coursework in their teacher preparation program, and 3) their experiences as teachers have influenced their approach to teaching culturally and linguistically diverse students. The prompt indicated the topics of the narrative but allowed the participants to choose the organizational structure of their texts. The researcher sent the prompt to the early childhood teachers via email. The participants had two weeks to work on their texts once they received the prompt.

Semi-structured interviews. Four weeks after the written narratives, the participants were invited to engage in an interview via Zoom. The interview allowed the researcher to get more in-depth reflections from the participants about relevant aspects of the narrative to investigate the research questions. The interview's interactive nature gave the interviewer a chance to explore different paths on the topic of interest that participants may have left unattended during the written narrative and reflect or expand on what they wrote. The interview is semi-structured, with a

protocol used as a guide for talking about relevant topics, but with enough space to use probes to delve into interesting aspects of the participants' answers (Roulston, 2010). The main interview topics were participants' motivation to become teachers, personal experiences related to teaching CLD students, the influence of their teacher education program on their professional identity to work with CLD students, and their professional future. The conversations had a length of 40–60 min. Interviews were audio recorded and later transcribed.

3.5. Data analysis

The analysis was conducted using Dedoose, software for analyzing qualitative and mixed methods data. Data analysis was a sequential and iterative process. It was sequential because once I collected the first source of data, the written narratives, I carried out a first cycle of coding using initial coding (Saldaña, 2009) to get a preliminary approximation of developing categories within the data. For this process, I used as initial codes the factors that the literature described as influencing teacher identity: personal factors, experience as a pupil, teacher education, and biographical projects. Using what each participant shared in their written narratives on each code, I coded and noted each of the interviews.

The analysis was also iterative. After the data collection process was finished, I conducted descriptive coding of both the written narratives and interviews of each participant to find patterns and identify themes. For some of the initial codes, I identified sub-codes that illuminated specific aspects of each of the factors. I included codes related to cultural and linguistic diversity to better understand the relationship between those codes and those based on general factors. I also added a code for emotions to the analysis because those categories emerged as helpful in providing insights into the participants' perspectives and worldviews (Saldaña, 2009).

Subsequently, in the second cycle, I engaged with pattern coding (Saldaña, 2009) to refine and reconfigure the initial codes generated for the written narratives and interviews. To support this process, I used the Code Co-occurrence (when two codes were applied to the same fragment) and Code Application charts (how many times each code was applied) generated in Dedoose. Later, I read the quotes for each code while considering the charts, which helped to identify patterns in how each participant constructed their professional identity.

Table 2 shows the final coding scheme used in this study.

4. Findings

Across the written narratives and interviews, participants in this study described the process of constructing their teacher identities to work with culturally and linguistically diverse students. All participants discussed how their personal lives, previous experiences working with children, teacher preparation program, and desires for the future contributed to developing their teacher

Table 1
Participants.

Pseudonym	Age	Birthplace	Educational experiences before the teacher education program	Classroom experience before teacher education program	Languages Spoken
Estela	23 years	Santiago, Chile	Studied two years of a BA in Fine Arts	One year and a half working as a paraprofessional in a preschool	Spanish native. Fluent in English, learnt some German in school
Toti	22 years	Santiago, Chile	Graduated as paraprofessional from a vocational school	Two years working as a paraprofessional in a nursery school	Spanish native. Some English from school and college (described struggling with it)
Emilia	23 years	Santiago, Chile	Finished high school	None	Spanish native. Some English from school and college (described struggling with it)

Table 2
Coding scheme.

Code	Sub-Codes	Code Definition
Cultural and linguistic diversity		Participants refer to experiences or thoughts on cultural and linguistic diversity related to their students or in general.
	Experiences with cultural and linguistic diversity	Descriptions of having contact with culturally and linguistically diverse people in academic or social contexts.
	Perspectives about cultural and linguistic diversity	Participants discuss their perspectives about cultural and linguistic diversity in the classrooms and outside of them, connected with experiences.
	Linguistic reflections	Reflections about language and bilingualism in general, not necessarily connected to concrete experiences.
Teacher preparation		Participants refer to experiences during their teacher preparation program.
	Courses and contents	Discussions of how the coursework in their teacher education program contributed to their teacher identity.
	Practicum experiences	Experiences in practicums that were key in the development of participants' teacher identity.
	Influential people	Professors and other people in their teacher education program who influenced how participants see themselves as teachers.
	What was missing	Discussion of aspects participants wish were included in their teacher education program but were not part of it.
Professional future		Participants discuss their vision of their professional future.
Reasons to become an early childhood teacher/previous experience with children		Participants discuss why they decided to become early childhood teachers. There may be references to previous experiences working with children.
What does it mean to be an early childhood teacher		Participants refer to their conception of how early childhood teachers should be and what it means to them to be one.
Emotions Code		Participants' emotional reactions related to the aspects they shared in their narratives or interviews. This code co-occurs with others to indicate episodes of great relevance to the participants.

identity for working with CLD students. Findings reveal how participants are inclined to fight injustices in the Chilean school system and construct their teacher identity from their individual positionings, according to their interests and experiences.

Findings are organized by participant to highlight relevant themes in the professional identity construction of each teacher. Each case describes the elements that affected the teachers' professional identity development and how those have supported their perspective on working with CLD students, in order to answer the research questions.

4.1. Estela: passionate about language

In her written narrative and interview, Estela constructed her teacher identity as an advocate for her immigrant-origin students. In this construction, her personal experiences and what she learned in her teacher education program, especially related to language and literacy, are crucial elements in her professional identity. For Estela, understanding the theoretical aspects of language development in contexts of diversity is connected to having an emotional investment in her work.

During the interview, when discussing why she became an early childhood teacher, she talked about her experiences working as a paraprofessional in a preschool before starting her teacher education program. There, working with children living in difficult conditions, she recounted: “me di cuenta de que era lo que a mí me importaba, en quien quería convertirme y cómo podía hacerlo para convertirme en alguien de utilidad en su vida, en alguien que realmente pudiese hacer una diferencia” [I realized what mattered to me, in who I wanted to become, and how could I do to become someone useful in her life, in someone who could really make a difference].² When Estela described her work in that preschool setting, she used many expressions related to her emotional response to events. For instance, she said that some of her students were “en un riesgo severo, muy doloroso. Me da mucha pena

recordarlo” [in severe risk, very painful. It deeply saddens me to remember it]. Those feelings of hurt were not all that she felt, though. In the written narrative, she also mentioned feeling that her role was valuable. As she stated, she felt “la educadora más afortunada del mundo” [the luckiest teacher in the world], and that “yo sentía mucho amor” [I felt a lot of love] in that educational context. Estela's motivation to become a teacher started an identity construction as someone with an ethical obligation to her work and who ties her ethics with her emotions.

While Estela did not mention cultural and linguistic diversity in her reasons to become a teacher, she did make a connection between diversity and her personal experiences. In the interview, she revealed that she had many Venezuelan friends. She reflected on their situation in Chile related to her role as a teacher: “yo considero que ha de ser muy triste tener un hijo que te has tenido que gastar miles de dólares en sacar de tu país [...] Y tener que dejárselo a un extraño. Y a un extraño en una escuela [...] que no tienes idea si sabe algo de su cultura” [I consider that it must be very sad to have a child in whom you have spent thousands of dollars getting them out of your country [...] And have to leave them to a stranger. And to a stranger in a school, who you don't know if they know anything about his culture]. Even in her references to her personal life, Estela's reflections led her to think about school children. Estela's personal and professional selves impact each other, contributing to the construction of a richer and more nuanced teacher identity.

This worry about how immigrant-origin children are treated in schools is central to Estela's teacher identity construction. For example, Estela recalls one particular event in one of her practicums which was presented as a critical incident in both her written narrative and the interview. In a preschool located in a low-income area of Santiago, there was a Haitian student, Paul, two and a half years old. Estela narrated that “Una mañana, le hablé al niño para pedirle algo, y la educadora me dijo las siguientes palabras, que nunca olvidaré: “no pierdas tu tiempo hablándole a Paul, porque como habla haitiano no te entiende nada” [One morning, I talked to the boy to ask him something, and the teacher told me the following words, which I will never forget: “Don't lose your time talking to Paul because as he speaks Haitian, he doesn't understand

² The author decided to include the words of the participants in their original language, Spanish, in addition to an English translation made by herself and verified by a Spanish/English bilingual researcher.

anything]. Estela's description of her reaction to this incident, both from the intellect and the heart, connects to her professional identity.

From a professional perspective, she answered to the teacher: "Yo sutilmente le corregí y le dije: Yo tengo entendido que los padres de Paul, a pesar de ser haitianos, hablan español además de creole. O sea, para partir no se llama haitiano el idioma, se llama creole" [And I subtly corrected her and told her: To my knowledge, Paul's parents, despite being Haitians, they speak Spanish in addition to Creole. By the way, to start, the language is not called Haitian; it is called Creole]. From her emotional perspective, she described: "Y a mí, te juro que de verdad yo sentía mi sangre helada por dentro. Estaba muy enojada" [And I, I swear that I truly felt my blood cold inside. I was very angry]. In that situation, Estela acted professionally and responded to the teacher based on her knowledge but, as a teacher who is not indifferent to discrimination, her emotions were a central part of how she recounted the event.

Estela's identity as someone enthusiastic also appeared as a theme when discussing her interest in language in the context of her teacher education program. In relation to this, she said in the interview: "Yo de verdad considero que estoy loca y que estoy obsesionada con el lenguaje. Y ese curso y tú dieron totalmente cuerda a esta locura" [I truly consider that I am crazy and obsessed with language. And that course and you completely resonated with that craziness]. Estela's courses on language development and early literacy allowed her to pose questions and have conversations about all these topics. In the interview, she constantly reflected on linguistic issues when discussing cultural and linguistic diversity. For instance, she said: "En Latinoamérica, tenemos hartos países que hablamos español igualmente, pero [...] a pesar de que hablemos español, hay unas diferencias lingüísticas preciosas" [In Latin America, we have several countries that speak Spanish, but despite all of us speaking Spanish, there are beautiful linguistic differences]. By caring about language issues, Estela constructed an identity as a teacher who understands language diversity as positive and enriching and is enthusiastic about learning to be better at her job. In the interview, she connected this interest with her professional future: "En cinco años más yo voy a ser especialista en didáctica del lenguaje. Donde sea, como sea, pero lo voy a hacer" [In five years, I am going to be a specialist in language instruction. Wherever, however, but I am going to do it].

When discussing her teacher education program, the courses on language and literacy were not the only ones that helped Estela construct her professional identity. In the interview, she specifically mentioned the courses of Teacher Identity Construction, Education for Human Rights and Sexual Diversity, and Current Perspectives on Childhood and Family. For Estela, those courses were instances where the professors as individuals and the content of the course helped her develop "una perspectiva súper clara de lo que yo quiero conseguir como educadora, de cuáles son mis metas con mis estudiantes" [a clear perspective of what I want to achieve as a teacher, of which are my goals with my students]. For Estela, those courses were crucial to discover what kind of teacher she wanted to be.

In sum, Estela's teacher identity is shaped by her interest in language, her drive to advocate for diverse students, the idea that feelings are central to her work, some key courses in her teacher education program, and her personal experiences as a friend of immigrants. All factors contribute to and allow her to construct a teacher identity responsive to teaching CLD students.

4.2. Toti: education for all children

Toti, who studied to be a paraprofessional in a vocational high school, has been preparing to work with children since very early.

She constructed her teacher identity to work with CLD students mainly from her interest in special education and her willingness to include all children in the classroom, but also rooted in her personal experiences. Interestingly, Toti, both in her written narrative and interview, connected each main idea with recounting a critical event. In that way, she constructed her teacher identity from concrete experiences that contributed to her understanding of her role as a teacher.

Toti's motivation to become a teacher is grounded in one of the events that Toti recalled. In her written narrative, Toti described how one of her classmates in school was discriminated against by some teachers for being a darker skin immigrant and how Toti and her classmates supported that student academically and personally. As the conclusion of this story, she stated: "Quizás suene un tanto cliché, pero desde ese momento supe que quería enseñar y que era eso lo que me apasionaba" [Maybe it is a cliché, but from that moment I knew that I wanted to teach and that this was my passion]. This quote shows how Toti conceived her teacher identity from its conception as connected to fighting discrimination.

The same point of view is reflected in various moments in the written narrative and interview when Toti defined what it meant for her to be a teacher. Referring to her personal identity, Toti wrote that " [al] ser una mujer que pertenece a la comunidad LGBTQI + y tener un grupo cercano que también se relaciona con eso, entendí que la educación debe ser libre de prejuicios y llena de igualdad e inclusión" [being a woman who belongs to the LGBTQI + community and having a close group that is also related to that, I understood that education should be free of prejudice and filled with equity and inclusion]. According to Toti, the experience of belonging to a group of people who are often stigmatized influenced her teacher identity by making her more aware of the challenges different groups of students face in the classroom. For Toti, her personal identity has impacted her ability to identify with diverse students, which in turn, defines the kind of early childhood teacher she is.

Having studied to be a paraprofessional in high school, Toti had teaching experience before entering college. As a student and then working, Toti had the chance to see the reality immigrant-origin students face in preschool classrooms. In her written narrative, she recounted one event that happened in one of her practicums as a paraprofessional: " [...] el 40% de los niños y niñas que asistían era peruanos o con padres provenientes de ese país, los cuales eran excluidos de manera absurda por las directivas de los juegos con los demás niños y niñas" [40% of boys and girls that attended were Peruvian or with parents from that country, and they were absurdly excluded by the principals from playing with the rest of the boys and girls]. She described that this event "marcó mi carrera docente" [was pivotal in her teaching career]. Fortunately, a subsequent work experience in a more inclusive context, "me devolvió las esperanzas en la educación" [restored my hope in education], and she decided to pursue her college studies in education. This crucial experience, added to her personal identity, positions Toti as an educator who is sensitive to the discrimination that immigrant-origin students face.

Concerning her teacher education program, Toti discussed the courses and professors who contributed the most to help develop her professional identity. She shared in the interview:

"Y siento que, así como cada profe como suma y sigue el granito de arena que han aportado en mí como persona. Y siento que [...] me ayudaron a, como a terminar de construir la educadora que soy. La educadora que cree en la igualdad de hombres y mujeres. [...] En que niños con discapacidades pueden estar en una sala con niños sin discapacidades" [And I feel that, each professor adds a grain of sand to me as a person. And I feel that they helped me to like finish constructing the early childhood

teacher I am. The teacher who beliefs in equality between men and women. [...] That children with disabilities can be in a classroom with children with no disabilities].

In this quote, Toti connects the contributions of professors in her teacher education program to her professional identity development. Because she already had experience in education, she considered that those key people helped her to continue constructing a teacher identity that had already started developing prior to her entering college. The elements Toti mentioned as part of her core beliefs refer to a broader conception of diversity, which includes disabilities, gender identity, and sexual orientation, but did not directly use the term cultural and linguistic diversity. In that regard, she mentioned the courses of Human Rights and Special Educational Needs as crucial in constructing her professional identity.

Related to her future aspirations, Toti declared a specific path for her career in the future. In the last paragraph of her written narrative, she stated:

“Quiero estudiar un posgrado y magíster en temas de inclusión, para alguna vez poder tener un aula completamente inclusiva y diversa, para que ningún niño o niña reciba ninguna diferenciación por su color de piel, idioma, discapacidad, problema, etc.” [I want to study a graduate program and masters in the topic of inclusion, so no children will be discriminated by their skin color, language, capacity, problem, etc.].

For Toti, her interest in issues of inclusion is not limited to students with disabilities but includes anyone who is seen as different. Accordig to her, following a specialization in inclusion is a tool to keep building on her professional identity as a teacher who cares about all her students. While Toti asserted the intention of following her education, she was also unequivocal in positioning herself in the classroom, working directly with children, and taking direct action against discrimination.

In summary, Toti constructed a teacher identity as someone concerned about discrimination in Chilean classrooms. Her stance is deeply connected to her personal identity as a member of the LGBTQI+ community and has been present since she was a school student. Regarding her teacher identity to work with culturally and linguistically diverse students, she referenced this topic in the narrations about her experiences in the classroom, but not directly in connection to what she learned in the teacher education program. Mainly, Toti seemed to include CLD students in her aspiration to create inclusive classroom environments.

4.3. Emilia: fighter against injustices

Emilia, a recently graduated early childhood teacher with years of volunteering experience, constructed a professional identity to work with culturally and linguistically diverse students that positions her as an advocate and allows her to identify and combat discriminatory practices towards CLD students. This commitment to activism as a teacher was reflected in the interview when Emilia discussed her reasons for becoming a teacher. In this regard, she asserted: “De hecho, una de mis principales motivaciones para dedicarme a la pedagogía es justamente las ganas de hacer justicia desde la sala de clases” [In fact, one of my main motivations to teach is precisely an eagerness to make justice from the classroom]. This conception of the classroom as a space of social action is one of the main components of Emilia's teacher identity.

Emilia's willingness to combat problems in education and in society is also reflected in the critical event that made her want to

follow the path of education. In the interview, she narrated her experience volunteering in a rural school in the south of Chile. As a conclusion for that event, Emilia concluded: “Yo quiero actuar acá. Yo quiero estar con estas niñas, quiero darles las oportunidades” [I want to act here. I want to be with these girls, I want to give them the opportunities]. For Emilia, the desire to become a teacher stemmed from experiential knowledge about the reality and challenges of Chilean education and the needs existent in the educational system.

Emilia's desire to act against injustices is a very personal endeavor, reflected in her choice of words. In the written narrative, while discussing her motivations for becoming a teacher, Emilia explained that “siempre me han molestado las injusticias e, incluso, me afectan muchísimo en lo que respecta a lo emocional” (“I have always been bothered by injustices and they affect me very much emotionally”). By stating that she was *bothered* and *affected* by injustices, Emilia affirmed that her commitment to education was born from intellectual and ethical concerns about education and her emotional response as a human.

In relation to how the teacher education program supported Emilia to keep developing an identity to work with culturally and linguistically diverse students, she assessed positively the program, by writing “Me considero una educadora con una formación que me ha dado las herramientas necesarias para entender la diversidad y la multiculturalidad como una oportunidad para enriquecer el proceso de enseñanza-aprendizaje en vez de una dificultad” [I consider myself as a teacher with a preparation that gave me the tools needed to understand diversity and multiculturality as an opportunity to enrich the teaching-learning process instead of a difficulty]. For Emilia, an asset-based approach was the crucial attribute of her teacher preparation program that supported her to develop a positive perspective towards cultural and linguistic diversity.

In the written narrative, Emilia was more specific about the perspective that allowed her to develop that orientation. She described: “A lo largo de mi formación universitaria considero que, de manera transversal, se ha dado énfasis en lo que respecta a la multiculturalidad ya que existe un potente enfoque de derechos humanos el cual nos ha orientado en nuestro quehacer pedagógico” [Throughout my university preparation, I consider that, in a transversal way, there has been emphasis in regard to multiculturality because there is a strong focus on human rights which has oriented us in our teacher practices]. Like Estela and Toti, Emilia mentioned human rights as one of the pillars that prepared her to work with CLD students. It is interesting how Emilia shares similar values with the program's vision of education; thus, her teacher identity continued developing in a congruent direction.

While Emilia discussed her practicum experiences, she described how they allowed her to realize that those ideas that were hers and were promulgated by her teacher education program were not as widespread in actual classrooms. When faced with reality, in the interview, she described:

A mí me faltó [...] también de tener herramientas para enfrentarse a cosas que no te enseñan explícitamente [...] porque actualmente tenemos muchos estudiantes, de familias muy diversas y al parecer no estábamos tan preparados para, para poder recibir esta diversidad como una oportunidad. Porque he sido testigo de prácticas súper violentas en general, así como desde apoderados hasta los mismos docentes [I missed also having tools to face situations you are not taught about explicitly. Because currently we have many students, from very diverse families, and apparently, we were not as prepared to, to receive this diversity as an opportunity, because I have

witnessed very violent practices in general, from parents to even teachers].

For Emilia, the principles she had developed in her life and those supported by her teacher education program contrasted with the reality that student teachers faced when going to practicum in schools. She realized that being trained to work in less than ideal classrooms is essential for teachers to become effective with CLD students. She wished she was better prepared to deal with the reality of classroom teaching, specifically knowing when and how to step in situations of discrimination. As Emilia explains, this is an aspect of teaching that she had no support in developing and, thus, is insecure about in her current practice.

When discussing teaching CLD students in the written narrative and interview, Emilia made statements about her principles concerning language diversity and her role as a teacher. In the interview, she reflected

La lengua materna es parte de la identidad de un niño y que no se le puede negar, por lo que uno como docente, como garante de sus derechos, tiene que hacerse cargo y ver esto como una oportunidad enriquecedora [The mother language is part of a child's identity, and it cannot be denied to them, so one as a teacher, as guarantor of their rights, must take charge and recognize it as an enriching opportunity.]

Emilia's concern about the right of children to access their home language and the notion that native language is part of a person's identity was a strong theme that repeatedly appeared in her written narrative and interview. In this quote, those ideas are connected to one of Emilia's topics of interest: teachers as guarantors of students' rights. Emilia's teacher identity was built on the concept of teaching for justice, and that justice can only be achieved if teachers ensure that children's rights are being respected. For Emilia, students' home language should not only be valued for cognitive or educational reasons but because language maintenance is a human right.

Emilia expressed that her motivations and principles are crucial when thinking about her future, as shown in this quote: "yo creo que sea donde sea que yo me desenvuelva [...], siento que lo importante es como no perder como el norte y lo que a mí me motivó desde un comienzo" [I believe that wherever I work, I feel that it is important not to lose my way and what motivated me from the beginning]. This ethos, present in every element of Emilia's teacher identity, was a cornerstone that led her to the future. Unlike her colleagues, Emilia did not have concrete plans for the following years. Instead, she saw herself in a place where she could implement her educational philosophy.

The different aspects of Emilia's teacher identity formation connect and build upon each other toward her future vision. She established herself as a teacher of CLD students from a place of advocacy, guaranteeing children's rights and fighting injustices. While she constantly reflected on the value of home language and the principles that guide her work, Emilia was also concerned about how those issues are dealt with in the classrooms and how to work against discriminatory practices concretely with pedagogical strategies.

5. Discussion

This study investigated how three recently graduated early childhood educators from Santiago, Chile, constructed their teacher identities to work with culturally and linguistically diverse (CLD) students in a written narrative and an interview. Findings reveal

that the professional identities that emerged from the data are congruent with Akkerman, Meijer, Aronson, and Laughter's (2016) understanding of teacher identity as "as an ongoing process of negotiating and interrelating multiple I-positions in such a way that a more or less coherent and consistent sense of self is maintained throughout various participations and self-investments in one's (working) life" (p. 315). Estela, Toti, and Emilia discussed their teacher identities as the negotiation of multiple I-positions while maintaining a sense of self, which can be perceived in the consistency between what they expressed in their written narratives and the interviews. In this regard, findings from this study extend previous research by discussing identity in an international context and contributing to our understanding of teacher identity development.

Moreover, the participants were able to describe elements of their teacher identity that were related to their personal lives and their professional selves. However, a distinction between the two elements of identity seems unsuitable in cases where both are deeply interconnected, as when Estela added her teacher perspective when discussing her relationship with immigrant friends. As Akkerman et al. (2016) pointed out, although it is possible to distinguish the personal from the professional, if we understand identity as a self-dialogue between different I-positions, the boundaries between the two become indistinguishable.

In the continuing process of negotiating their multiple I-positions, the newly graduated teachers discussed several factors that contributed to the construction of their current teacher identity, in concordance with what is described in the literature. Studies on the construction of teacher identity includes several elements: reasons for entry into the profession, teacher education, current teaching context, career plans, prior personal experiences, and prior professional experiences (including working with kids) (Olsen, 2008). At the time of data collection, all the participants had experience working with children prior to starting their teacher education program, which influenced their teacher identity, in accordance with Friesen and Besley's (2013) findings about predictors of teacher identity development. What is interesting about the present study is that those previous experiences working with children were the basis in which Estela, Toti, and Emilia cemented their favorable predispositions to work with CLD students.

Related to the reasons for entry into the teaching profession, all three participants shared their desire to create more a more just society. These findings are not surprising given that the research literature on motivations for choosing the teaching profession, notes that altruistic, service-oriented goals are among the main reasons teacher candidates report for deciding on this career (Bastick, 2000; Brookhart & Freeman, 1992; Sinclair et al., 2006). In the case of Estela, Toti, and Emilia, this type of motivation is strengthened by comparable experiences of being treated unjustly or being close to people who have suffered discrimination.

With regard to the teacher education program, all participants described characteristics of the program that were similar or aligned to their personal values. In that way, the preparation for becoming a teacher contributed to developing their teacher identity by building on their existing beliefs and helping them become better equipped to discuss and confront these issues. In contrast, in their practicum, all participants recounted events in which they witnessed violent practices against immigrant-origin students. For them, those were shocking, catalytic incidents that conflicted with what they learned in their coursework and with their personal beliefs. When teaching in real classrooms, the harsh reality forced participants to add complexity to their professional identities, reinforce their initial commitment to justice and equity, and made them realize they needed to develop more pedagogical skills to deal with those situations.

Furthermore, findings from this study identified an emotional component as a notable aspect of teacher identity development. All participants described their emotional positioning towards their students, their work, and their experiences in the classroom. In the literature about emotional identity in the teaching profession, affect has been described as a central factor in developing teachers' professional identity (Hargreaves, 1998; Shapiro, 2010; Sutton & Wheatley, 2003). As Hargreaves (1998) stated, good teachers are "emotional, passionate beings who connect with their students and fill their work and their classes with pleasure, creativity, challenge and joy" (p. 835). In this regard, the participants' emotional reactions to teaching CLD students reflect their involvement in becoming responsive teachers.

Participants in this study seem to have developed positive attitudes and beliefs about working with culturally and linguistically diverse students, in agreement with theoretical perspectives on the preparation of responsive teachers in contexts of diversity (Lucas & Villegas, 2010; Pastori et al., 2018). Conversely, the participants seem not to have yet acquired other key aspects that will allow them to be competent teachers for CLD students, such as language-related knowledge and skills, which they described as missing in their teacher preparation program. Their insecurities are similar to those shared by student teachers in Sanhueza Henríquez et al.'s (2016) study. From the perspective of increasing teachers' intercultural competences, the literature suggests that the teachers in this study would benefit from professional development embedded in their context of practice, guided by critical reflection, and supporting the enactment of the newly acquired perspectives (Romijn et al., 2021).

Some implications for policy and practice can be drawn from this study. First, teacher education programs should leverage students' previous experiences, motivation, and values as a starting point in their preparation to work with CLD students. Student teachers bring a personal identity that can be used as an asset to building a more culturally and linguistically responsive teaching force. Second, although participants consider that their teacher preparation program contributed to their teachers' identity construction to work with CLD, another implication is that teacher education programs should offer more explicit instruction on pedagogical skills that contribute to the linguistic development of CLD students. A third implication is related to higher education policy. If Chile is committed to preparing teachers to serve an increasingly diverse student body, it is necessary that the standards for teacher education programs include the development of pedagogical skills to work in contexts of cultural and linguistic diversity. Policymakers are doing a disservice to both teachers and students by leaving the decision whether to include those elements and how to universities.

Despite its strengths, this study has some limitations that must be discussed. First, given that this a case study, working with a small number of participants, the intention is not to make generalizations about the development of teacher identity in the general population of early childhood teachers in Chile, but to give insights into the participants' experiences. In a follow-up study, it would be interesting to work with a larger pool of participants from diverse institutions to ascertain if their identity development is similar to those of Toti, Estela, and Emilia. Moreover, by working with the participants in one moment, this study could not address how participants developed their teacher identity over the course of their teacher preparation and as they started their professional trajectory. A longitudinal study would help illuminate the relevance of the factors that affect teacher identity development over time.

6. Conclusions

Findings from this study highlight how early childhood educators who recently graduated from a program that did not explicitly include cultural and linguistic diversity issues in its curriculum construct their teacher identities. While Sanhueza Henríquez et al. (2016) reported that Chilean student teachers did not feel prepared to work in the context of diversity, the early childhood educators in this study were able to construct a teacher identity with positive orientations and beliefs towards cultural and linguistic diversity. Understanding that identity does not necessarily reflect an individual's actions, it would be interesting to investigate if this positive representation of the self may have some connection with the ability of the participants to be effective teachers.

The fact that the participants in this study were able to construct an identity for working with culturally and linguistically diverse students, even having graduated from a program that did not emphasize those elements, indicates a great potential for teacher education programs. Considering that former students such as Estela, Toti, and Emilia put effort into figuring out and reflecting on how to work more effectively with diverse students and are eager to learn more, educational programs should leverage students' interests and identities in the design of programs that better prepare them to work in contexts of increasing cultural and linguistic diversity.

Funding

This research did not receive any specific grant from funding agencies in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data availability

The authors do not have permission to share data.

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